Assignment: Personal Data and Data Storage

1. LinkedIn

a. What data does LinkedIn store about me?

I requested and downloaded a copy of my LinkedIn data. The export contains information about my professional profile, activity, connections, and use of the platform.

Downloaded archive size: 124,219 bytes

The export contains 37 files. These include:
- Profile information, education, work experience, skills, and volunteering.
- Connections, invitations, followers, and company follows.
- Messages, comments, shares, and reposts.
- Search queries, saved job alerts, job preferences, and learning activity.
- Email addresses, phone numbers, login records, and security information.
- Advertising clicks, advertising targeting information, and inferences about me.

The export shows that LinkedIn stores more than the information I deliberately publish on my profile. It also contains records of my activity, communications, and interactions with the platform.

Steps used to download the data:
1. I opened LinkedIn and signed in to my account.
2. I opened Settings & Privacy and selected Data privacy.
3. I selected Get a copy of your data.
4. I requested the available data archive and waited for LinkedIn to prepare it.
5. I downloaded the archive and checked its file size.

LinkedIn provides a way for members to access their personal data through its account settings.

b. Where is my LinkedIn data stored?

LinkedIn's privacy policy states that it processes information both inside and outside the United States and that data may be stored and used outside the country where a member lives. LinkedIn's published data-security documentation also states that its customer and personal data is stored in data centers in the United States. It describes the use of distributed data storage and multiple geographic locations for redundancy. Based on these sources, the best-supported conclusion is that my LinkedIn data is stored in LinkedIn's distributed data-center infrastructure, including facilities in the United States. The company also processes data internationally.

However, I cannot identify the exact building, street address, city, or state where my particular account's data is stored. LinkedIn does not identify an individual user's storage location in the downloaded archive or the cited public documents.

2. Facebook

a. What data does Facebook store about me?

I requested and downloaded a copy of my Facebook information. The archive contains 338 files, including records of my activity and information associated with my account.

Downloaded archive size: 14,826,983 bytes

The export contains information in several categories:
- Messages and messaging settings, including records related to Messenger.
- Photos and other media shared or received through the platform.?
- Account information and settings.
- Activity records, including interactions with Facebook content.
- Records of how I use Facebook and related services.

The export demonstrates that Facebook retains information beyond the basic details shown on my profile. It also contains information about my communications and activity.

Steps used to download the data:
1. I opened Facebook and signed in to my account.
2. I opened Settings & Privacy and selected Settings.
3. I opened Accounts Center and selected Your information and permissions.
4. I selected Export your information and chose my Facebook account.
5. I requested an export, selected the information to include, and downloaded the archive once it was ready.

b. Where is my Facebook data stored?

Facebook is owned by Meta, which operates a global network of data centers to support its applications and services. Meta's official data-center website identifies facilities in several countries, including the United States, Ireland, Denmark, Sweden, and Singapore. These facilities provide the physical infrastructure used to store, process, and manage information for Meta's services, including Facebook and Messenger.

Based on this information, my Facebook data may be stored in Meta's global data-center infrastructure. However, the export does not identify the exact physical location of my account's data. I cannot confirm whether my information is stored in Canada, the United States, or another country. Meta's public information identifies its data-center locations, but it does not establish which facility contains my particular account's records.

Conclusion

After examining both exports, I found that LinkedIn and Facebook collect and retain substantial amounts of information about their users. LinkedIn's archive contains professional information, communications, account activity, and advertising-related records. Facebook's archive contains account information, messages, photos, and activity records. The data exports also demonstrate that requesting a copy of personal information is an effective way to learn what information a platform retains. However, identifying the exact physical location of an individual user's data is more difficult because companies generally do not disclose that information in their exports or public data-center listings.